Heavy cruiser Nachi
The Japanese cruiser *Nachi* and her sister ship *Haguro* outclassed their opponents at the battle of the Java Sea. *Nachi*'s longlance torpedoes, more reliable than the Allied torpedoes, sunk the Dutch light cruiser *Java*.



WORLD WAR II

JAVA SEA



Date February 27–March 1,1942
Forces Allies: 5 cruisers, 9 destroyers; Japanese: 4 cruisers; 14 destroyers
Losses Allies: 5 cruisers; 5 destroyers; Japanese: 4 troop transports

Location
Java Sea

An American-British-Dutch-Australian (ABDA) force under Dutch admiral Karel Doorman was created to prevent the Japanese landing troops on Java. On February 27, 1942, an invasion force was spotted and Doorman sailed from Surabaya to intercept it. His force consisted of two heavy cruisers—the Royal Navy's *Exeter* and the US Navy's *Houston*—one Australian and two Dutch light cruisers, and nine destroyers, four of them American. They found the Japanese troop transports defended by Admiral Shoji Nishimura with the heavy cruisers *Nachi* and *Haguro* supported by light cruisers and destroyers.

Although on paper the two forces were comparable, the Japanese were superior in guns, torpedoes, organization, and morale. After two hours' gunfire *Exeter* withdrew from battle after a hit on her boiler room and two ABDA destroyers were sunk. At around 6:00 p.m.



Dutch medallion
Admiral Doorman's flagship *De Ruyter* appears below his reputed last words at the battle of the Java Sea: "I'm attacking, follow me."

WORLD WAR II

CORAL SEA



Date May 4–8, 1942
Forces US and Australians: 2 carriers, 8 cruisers, 13 destroyers; Japanese: 2 carriers, 1 light carrier, 6 cruisers, 6 destroyers
Losses US and Australians: 1 carrier, 1 destroyer, 74 aircraft; Japanese; 1 light carrier, 1 destroyer, 70 aircraft

Location
Coral Sea

In April 1942 the Japanese, pushing south toward Australia, sent a force to occupy Tulagi in the Solomon Islands and Port Moresby in New Guinea, supported by the carriers *Shokaku* and *Zuikaku*. The US Navy was well informed of Japanese plans through radio intercepts and Rear Admiral Frank Fletcher was ordered to seek out and attack the Japanese forces. He assembled the carriers *Lexington* and *Yorktown* and a number of cruisers and destroyers in the Coral Sea, including a contingent from the Royal Australian Navy under Rear Admiral John Crace.

The Americans struck the first blow on May 4 when aircraft from *Yorktown* attacked the Japanese at Tulagi, sinking a destroyer and several merchant vessels. For the next two days the rival carrier forces, concealed by cloud cover, failed to find one another. Fletcher was, however, informed of the course of the invasion force bound for Port Moresby, which was located by the US Army Air Force. On May 7 carrier aircraft attacked the Japanese troop convoy escorts. US fliers piled in to sink the light carrier *Shohu* with a plethora of torpedoes and bombs. But the overkill on a single ship meant other available targets were neglected. Meanwhile, Japanese carrier aircraft attacked and sank an American destroyer and oil tanker that had been mistakenly identified as a carrier and a cruiser. As night fell six Japanese planes tried to land on *Yorktown*, believing it was one of their own ships.

The following morning both sides flew off their aircraft to attack. Many of the American pilots had trouble finding the Japanese carriers, which were sailing through a tropical rainstorm. *Zuikaku* escaped in the poor visibility but *Shokaku* was left ablaze and incapable of operating aircraft. Meanwhile, Japanese bombers, enjoying better conditions, attacked with excellent coordination. *Yorktown* was hit by a bomb that exploded below decks, killing or seriously injuring 66.

